

Number Numbness

That's what Excel takes care of. Make no mistake: Excel is a very, very powerful data handler. From cosmetic enhancements to advanced analysis, Excel does it all.

The latest version—Excel 2007, which this little book covers—has undergone more changes in this release of the Microsoft Office suite than have the other programs. With so many of us upgrading to Office 2007, we felt the need to cover Excel 2007 in detail, even though we introduced Excel in an earlier *Fast Track* edition.

Our purpose here is threefold. First, to give you a feel for the new (2007) interface and functionalities; second, to give you an idea of much that Excel is capable of doing; and third, to guide you through some topics in detail, so you can get Excel to work well for you.

After starting off with the basics, we go into the details of data presentation—that is, formatting, alignment, and such. Next come several chapters on actually dealing with data, such as dealing with cell references, sorting, organising data into levels, and such. A chapter on PivotTables exposes you to this wonderfully useful tool. Then comes the topic of charts, one of the primary uses for Excel—visualising data.

We've included two little chapters on macros and graphic elements respectively, and we round off with a chapter on Excel formulas and functions.

We candidly admit that because of its complexity, Excel is a hard topic to cover in perfect detail. You might just find that, for example, a macro or a formula doesn't work exactly as we've explained. In such cases, thankfully, there's always Excel's Help pages to refer to. But we should reiterate that we've striven to make this book such that you'll need to refer to the Help as little as possible, except in the case of formulas and functions, which could fill three entire *Fast Track* editions!

If you've got data to handle, you need Excel. And if you've got Excel, you need this book. And if you've got this book, you're on your way to unleash the capabilities of the best spreadsheet app of all time—well begun is half done!